4

Language Acquisition and Socialization

> Language is a great force of socialization, probably the greatest that exists.
>
> Edward Sapir (1949[1933]:15)

Katie, a three-month-old infant from a white, middle-class family in the United States, sits perched on her mother's knees. Katie and her mother face each other and have a "conversation." "Glrgg," Katie gurgles. "Hello to you, too," her mother replies in a high-pitched, singsong voice sometimes called baby talk, motherese, or parentese. Katie turns her head to the side. Her mother follows her gaze. "Is Katie looking at the doggie? What's the doggie's name?" Katie remains silent, but her mother continues the conversation: "That's right – Spot!" In this way, Katie's mother interprets, replies to, or comments upon each sound or gesture Katie makes. Katie's mother willingly "converses" with Katie and thereby attributes intentionality and some semblance of intelligibility to Katie's prelinguistic utterances. This type of interaction is often taken for granted by people raised in homes similar to Katie's. Indeed, to such people it may seem like the only "appropriate" or "natural" way to talk to a baby, and some even think it is necessary to speak this way in order for children to learn a language – but linguistic anthropologists have shown that this way of using language with infants is "characteristic neither of all societies nor of all social groups (e.g., all social classes within one society)" (Ochs and

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Schieffelin 2001[1984]:268). Such research demonstrates that there are multiple ways of becoming fluent in one's native language(s) and becoming socialized into one's culture(s).

Consider the case of Bage, a three-month-old Kaluli boy, for example, whose language socialization process is described by Bambi Schieffelin (1990) in her ethnography about the Kaluli people of Papua New Guinea. Unlike Katie, who sat perched on her mother's knee for a face-to-face "conversation," Bage is held facing outward on his mother's lap so as to see and be seen by a larger group of household members. Bage's mother does not address him directly, as the Kaluli do not consider infants to be appropriate conversation partners, and she does not use baby talk. Instead, she involves Bage's almost-three-year-old older brother, Abi, in an exchange in which she takes Bage's role. In this triadic exchange, which is typical among the Kaluli, Bage's mother speaks "for" the infant, addressing Abi using the appropriate kinship term for brother and asking Abi to pick him up. "When speaking as the infant to older children," Schieffelin writes, "mothers speak assertively; that is, they never whine or beg on behalf of infants. Thus, in taking this role, mothers do for infants what they cannot do for themselves: act in a controlled and competent manner using language" (1990:72). In refusing to address their infants directly or to simplify the grammar of their utterances at all, Kaluli mothers show that they think very differently about infants as language learners and as social actors than mothers such as Katie's do.

In these two examples, as well as in many others (e.g., Crago et al. 1997; Demuth 1986; Heath 1983; Duranti, Ochs, and Schieffelin 2011; Ochs 1988), we can see care-givers socializing their children into becoming very different kinds of social beings *through culturally specific uses of language*. In the case of Katie, her mother was promoting a certain sense of self by interacting with her as if she were already a competent communicative partner. Such one-on-one interactions are part of a wider set of cultural practices and language ideologies in the United States surrounding child-rearing, most of which involve accommodating the situation to the child rather than adapting the child to the situation. Middle-class caregivers in the United States engage in two related practices, according to Elinor Ochs and Bambi Schieffelin: "self-lowering" on the part of caregivers, exemplified by simplifying their utterances and asking questions to which they already know the answers; and "child-raising," that is, treating the child as more competent linguistically than she really is (Ochs and

Schieffelin 2001:272, 287). In Papua New Guinea, in contrast, Bage's attention was directed outwards toward a more sizable family group as he was being socialized into a network of kin. His mother did not employ "self-lowering" or "child-raising" in interacting with Bage; indeed, his mother did not converse with Bage directly at all. Instead, Bage was expected to accommodate to the wider social group as he learned appropriate ways of interacting linguistically and culturally.

These two examples raise many fascinating questions about the process of language acquisition and socialization, several of which are addressed in this chapter: (1) How does the innate human capacity to learn a language intersect with the culturally and linguistically specific factors in each child's upbringing? (2) In bilingual or multilingual environments, do socialization practices have an impact on which languages children learn and to what levels of proficiency? (3) Does language socialization end when childhood ends, or does it continue into adulthood? In each of these areas, linguistic anthropology has a unique perspective to offer that sheds valuable light on the complex process of acquiring a language. Sometimes, this perspective complements the scholarship being done in other disciplines; other times, it challenges it.

Language Acquisition and the Socialization Process

The fact that children who are raised as differently as Katie and Bage nevertheless all become competent speakers of their native languages by about age three points to an undeniable innate component in the language acquisition process. The nature of this innate component, however, is hotly debated. Many linguists follow Noam Chomsky, who considers social or other environmental influences on language acquisition to be extremely limited. Chomsky also views language acquisition as a process over which children and their caregivers have very little control:

> Language learning is not really something that the child does; it is something that happens to the child placed in an appropriate environment, much as the child's body grows and matures in a predetermined way when provided with appropriate nutrition and environmental stimulation. (1999:41)

Not only do Chomsky and his supporters accord the environment a very minor role in the language acquisition process; they also believe

that language arises out of a separate domain-specific faculty or module of the brain. Without such a special "language-acquisition device" (LAD) (Chomsky 1999:43) or "language instinct" (Pinker 1994), these scholars argue, children would not be able to acquire language so quickly, given the "poverty of the stimulus" – in other words, given the supposedly impoverished nature of the input that a child receives linguistically during the first few years of life. Hard-wired into the brain, Chomsky and others maintain, is a "universal grammar" (UG) that provides an overarching template for the range of possible human languages. All a child needs to do, in this view, is to hear a few examples of any particular grammatical feature in order to be able to set the appropriate parameter, or switch, correctly in UG. For example, some languages place prepositions at the beginning of phrases (as in English – e.g., "*in* the house"), whereas in other languages, words such as "in" are called postpositions because they occur at the end of a phrase (as in Nepali – e.g., "ghar*mā*" – literally, "house *in*," more appropriately translated as "*in* the house"). Once a child is exposed to enough examples of such phrases in a given language, the parameter is thought to be switched to the correct setting in the child's brain.

Some linguists, cognitive scientists, and child development specialists disagree, however, with the Chomskyan view that there is a domain-specific language acquisition device or module in the brain. Instead, these scholars maintain that generalized cognitive and developmental processes or learning mechanisms enable children to acquire one or more languages in the same way that they learn other advanced cognitive tasks. Elizabeth Bates and Brian MacWhinney, for example, argue the following: "[T]he human capacity for language could be both innate and species-specific, and yet involve no mechanisms that evolved specifically and uniquely for language itself. Language could be viewed as a new machine constructed entirely out of old parts" (Bates and MacWhinney 1989:10, cited in Tomasello and Slobin 2005: xxvii).

In addition, some scholars (e.g., Givón 1985; Plunkett 1995; Snow 1995) dispute the characterization of the linguistic input received by children as impoverished – "very restricted and degenerate," according to Chomsky (1968:23) – and claim instead that most children are exposed to more than enough linguistic input to acquire a language without needing to postulate the hard-wiring of specific

linguistic features in Universal Grammar. Questions remain, however, as to how much and what kind of input is enough, and what effects early language exposure and different social environments have on children's language acquisition processes.

Whether the human capacity for language is the result of a language-specific module in the brain or a more generalized set of cognitive mechanisms, linguistic anthropologists maintain that social interactions play a crucial role in language acquisition, and it is here that the discipline of linguistic anthropology has a great deal to contribute to a deeper understanding of how children learn their native languages. "Language socialization" is the name of the subfield that delves into these issues. Established and still led by Elinor Ochs and Bambi Schieffelin, who have published independently and jointly on the topic of language socialization since the 1980s, the field takes the following as its two main propositions (Ochs and Schieffelin 2001:264):[1]

1 The process of acquiring language is deeply affected by the process of becoming a competent member of society.
2 The process of becoming a competent member of society is realized to a large extent through language.

The message to scholars interested in language acquisition, therefore, is that they should consider cultural values and social practices to be inseparable from language and its acquisition (Slobin 1992:6). And the message to cultural anthropologists and other social scientists interested in processes of childhood social practices, education, apprenticeship, or other ways of learning or entering into new social groups is that they should look closely at linguistic practices. In other words, learning a first language and becoming a culturally competent member of a society are two facets of a *single process*. It is virtually impossible for a child to learn a language without also becoming socialized into a particular cultural group, and, conversely, a child cannot become a competent member of such a group without mastering the appropriate linguistic practices. Indeed, the social category of age is itself produced by the culturally specific ways that older people in a given community interact with and speak to younger people, as Elise Berman (2019) has shown in her Marshall Islands research.

Elinor Ochs's (1988) research on language acquisition and socialization in Western Samoa is a case in point. The conclusions Ochs draws after rigorous, long-term fieldwork call into question some of the standard assumptions of child development specialists in other disciplines. For example, she challenges the claim that all children learn grammatical features in the same order and at roughly the same ages. Western Samoan children, Ochs discovered, acquire the particular grammatical feature known as an ergative marker[2] later than do children who speak other ergative languages such as Kaluli or Quiché Mayan (Ochs 1988:102; cf. Schieffelin 1990, Pye 1990). This is not because the ergative marker is more difficult to learn in Samoan than in other languages where it is used but because, Ochs argues, use of the ergative case in adult Samoan varies according to the degree of social intimacy or distance of the speakers – the more intimately related the speakers are, the less likely they are to use ergative markers (cf. Duranti 1994). Ochs also found that women used ergative markers less frequently than men. Thus, young Samoan children, who spent most of their first few years in the company of close, usually female, family members, heard relatively few ergative markers and therefore learned to use such markers themselves later than children learning other ergative languages.

But Ochs's research should not be interpreted to mean that language acquisition always proceeds according to a basic input–output model in which the grammatical features children learn earliest are those that they most frequently hear. Indeed, Ochs and Schieffelin (1995) present two telling examples of grammatical features that are not acquired by Samoan children according to such a simplistic process. In the first case, Samoan children frequently hear a term meaning "come" but rarely use it themselves because it is socially inappropriate for them to do so, given their lowly status in the household hierarchy. In the second example, Samoan children rarely hear but frequently use the imperative form of the compound verb meaning "having chewed, give." Such instances, Ochs and Schieffelin argue, "should sensitize us to the fact that children's linguistic repertoire is not a simple reflection of what they do or do not hear in their surroundings, but rather that children are taking an active role in constructing language that is most useful to their needs and appropriate to their social status" (Ochs and Schieffelin 1995:87–88).

Additional evidence that standard assumptions and methods for studying child language acquisition might need to be rethought comes from other scholars. The tendency, for example, for researchers to study mainly adult–child interactions ignores the possibility that child–child speech patterns might differ substantially from those found in traditional middle-class, white, English-speaking mother–child contexts. Indeed, in her study of Sesotho-speaking children's language acquisition and socialization processes in southern Africa, Katherine Demuth found that around the age of two and a half, usually about the age when a new sibling would be born, adults would turn their attention to the newborn, and toddlers were "thrust into the peer group to fend verbally, and otherwise, for themselves" (Demuth 1992:588). One concrete linguistic result of this shift in social context, Demuth maintains, is that Sesotho-speaking children use relative clauses ("the day when we went to the river" or "my box that I was given") quite a bit earlier than English-speaking children do. The Sesotho-speaking toddlers also use such complex clauses more often with their peers than with adults. The reason for this, Demuth suggests, is because peer groups are more confrontational and less accommodating to young children than adults often are, forcing them to make use of more complex linguistic features in order to hold their own socially (Demuth 1992:617). Adequate attention to naturally occurring peer interactions among English-speaking toddlers might reveal, Demuth suggests, that such youngsters can actually produce relative clauses earlier than was previously thought.

More research such as Demuth's across many different languages would certainly help to contextualize what is known about language acquisition, and might even lead scholars to reassess what were previously held to be universals in the order in which children learn various grammatical structures.

Gaps in the "Language Gap" Approach

Recently, popular educational initiatives have emerged that ignore decades of research by linguists and linguistic anthropologists (e.g., Avineri and Johnson 2015; Heath 1983; Ochs & Schieffelin 2008; Zentella 2005) concerning language socialization processes and the richness and diversity of home learning environments. These initiatives, such as Providence Talks (www.providencetalks.org), the Thirty Million Words

Initiative (tmw.org), and Too Small to Fail (toosmall.org), attempt to address in well-intentioned ways what they claim are linguistic deficits in young children that make it more difficult for them to succeed when they get to school. These organizations are based on studies (e.g., Hart and Risley 1995) that claim to have identified a 30-million-word "gap" in the first three years of life in the number of words to which children in low-income homes are exposed compared to children from high-income families. The organizations directly attribute differences in academic achievement to this purported gap, offering low-income families counseling so that parents can interact with their children in more a more "teacherly" manner. Parents and caregivers are also sometimes given "word pedometers" to provide them with adult word counts that encourage them to track the number of conversational interactions between parents and children.

Linguists and linguistic anthropologists have pointed out that these sorts of programs are seriously flawed, as they are based on assumptions about language, race, and impoverishment (both economic and linguistic) that are disproven by decades of evidence. In response to a spate of "Language Gaps" programs in the mid-2010s, an invited forum in the *Journal of Linguistic Anthropology* (Vol. 25, Issue 1) identified the following areas of critique:

1 Judgments concerning "gaps" or "deficits" are language ideologies. William Labov is justifiably famous for disproving the "verbal deprivation hypothesis" concerning African American children more than forty years ago, demonstrating the linguistically rule-governed nature of African American English (Labov 1972a, 1972b, 2010; Rosa and Flores 2015). (We will review this research in greater depth in chapter 11.) For many linguistic anthropologists, it is truly disheartening to see these sorts of unsubstantiated language ideologies emerge again in the form of the "Language Gap" programs. They argue that it is problematic to place the blame for poor academic performance solely on parents' linguistic interactions with their children, and they decry the programs' push to make parents' linguistic interactions more "teacherly." This often means having parents ask questions to which they already know the answers – a strangely unnatural and seemingly unnecessary discursive practice in many communities – then assessing children's answers as correct or incorrect.

("What color is this?" "Blue – right!") About this common classroom interactional routine, Susan Blum writes:

> The Providence Talks effort is to teach parents to act as teachers, rehearsing and pointing out school-rewarded aspects of the environment … These linguistic exchanges have no communicative function except to reward children with parents' approval for passing the test. They do teach children to crave adult approval; to wait passively for adults to initiate interaction; and to regard demonstration of known knowledge as one of the primary goals of children's speech. This notion of right and wrong answers and of passively pleasing caregivers is, indeed, matched by school testing, but it is problematic in school and equally problematic in homes … Bringing the worst of the teaching function into the heart of homes is the wrong direction; far better would be bringing the multifaceted playful uses of multiple forms of language into schools. (Blum 2015:75)

2 Shirley Brice Heath, author of a classic study that we will discuss later in the book on the diversity of orality and literacy practices in low-income homes, notes that despite copious research showing that only sustained, long-term, integrated programs are effective at improving school outcomes for poor children, programs such as Providence Talks continue to take an overly simplistic approach. "Scholars familiar with child development reproach such programs by pointing out that an increase in direct talk to infants and toddlers must work alongside economic and healthcare changes if impoverished children are to gain academic success and future employment with a living wage," Heath maintains (2015:68).

3 Rather than accept the status quo of unequal prestige for different ways of speaking, some scholars argue for a more forward-thinking way of appreciating the diversity of speech patterns across the US. "In fact," write H. Samy Alim and Django Paris,

> we posit that in this "new America," rather than children of color being framed in terms of "gaps," the linguistic and cultural flexibility of many children of color ideally positions them for success in a diversifying, globalizing world. Researchers are encouraged to think forward, not backward, in ways that both challenge hegemonic norms and support the flexibility that students will increasingly need for access and opportunity. (2015: 80)

Language Socialization in Bilingual or Multilingual Contexts

Additional insights can be gleaned from studying children learning to speak in bilingual or multilingual contexts. When children are exposed regularly to two or more languages (there does not seem to be an upper limit) during the developmental window period of early to middle childhood, they usually become fluent in all the languages available to them in their social environment. Contrary to language ideologies that hold that children are somehow disadvantaged by being exposed to more than one language in early childhood, many studies show, on the contrary, that there are significant cognitive advantages to being bilingual (e.g., Bialystok 2010; Bialystok and Viswanathan 2009). Research has demonstrated that bilingualism can improve areas of cognition unrelated to language and can even protect against dementia as a person ages. Bilingualism does not result automatically from mere exposure to two languages, however. There is evidence that social factors and language ideologies can sometimes prevent children from becoming fluent in a given language despite frequent exposure to it.

Don Kulick's (1992, 1998, 2019) writing about the acquisition and retention of two languages, the indigenous language of Taiap and the lingua franca Tok Pisin, in the village of Gapun, Papua New Guinea, reveals the influence of positive and negative attitudes on the acquisition (or lack thereof) of these two languages by children. As we read in one of the examples at the very beginning of this book, adult residents of Gapun, almost all of whom were bilingual in Taiap and Tok Pisin at the time of Kulick's fieldwork, told him that they were not responsible for their children learning to speak Tok Pisin instead of Taiap, the indigenous vernacular language. Kulick elaborates:

> In Gapun, parents explicitly see themselves not as acting, but as *re*-acting to language shift … Without exception, everyone agrees that Taiap is a good language and desirable to know. No conscious decision has been made by anyone to stop transmitting the vernacular to their children, and some villagers, especially old men, occasionally express great annoyance at the fact that children only speak Tok Pisin. So what, then, is causing the shift? The children, say the adults. "It's them,

> these little kids," explained one woman, echoing the conclusion of others and indicating her suckling 14-month-old baby with a sharp jab of her chin, "They're all *bikhed* [big-headed, strong-willed]. They don't want to know our village language. They just want to speak Tok Pisin all the time." (1992:12–13)

Kulick's ethnography seeks to explain the shift from Taiap to Tok Pisin in Gapun by drawing upon Marshall Sahlins's (1981) influential contribution to practice theory. Sahlins argues that people may be attempting to reproduce their cultural norms and social relations, but instead they often end up unwittingly transforming them because conditions have changed. As an example of this process, Sahlins examines Captain Cook's arrival in Hawaii in the eighteenth century. The Hawaiians mistook Cook for their god, Lono, and the actions that they subsequently took to try to worship him and reproduce their social system resulted in the colonization of their society and the complete overhaul of their belief system. Similarly, Kulick maintains, the residents of Gapun believed in the 1980s that they were reproducing their traditional values, but because of the arrival of new ideas and practices brought in by Christian missionaries, villagers ended up creating conditions that led to the shift in their children away from Taiap toward Tok Pisin.

Two long-standing Gapun cultural concepts, *hed* and *save*, are central to understanding why children in the village stopped learning Taiap. *Hed*, Kulick explains, is a trait that Gapun residents believe all people have to a greater or lesser extent. It is the dimension of the self that is "individualistic, irascible, selfish, unbending, haughty, and proud" (1992:19). *Save*, literally meaning knowledge, is a much more positive quality. It is the social, cooperative part of one's personality. "All people, but especially men," Kulick asserts, "are expected to use their *save*, their 'knowledge,' to 'suppress' (*daunim*) their antisocial *heds* and cooperate with their fellow villagers" (1992:19). Women and children are thought to be less capable of controlling their selfish, argumentative *heds*.

How can these two concepts of *hed* and *save* explain the language shift that occurred in Gapun? In the past, when only Taiap was spoken in the village, the negative associations of *hed* and the positive associations of *save* had no implications for language use. With the

advent of Christianity and a new language, Tok Pisin, in the village, however, these connotations were supplemented by new ones. *Hed* retained all its negative qualities but also came to be associated with Taiap and with what villagers thought of as being "backward." *Save*, on the other hand, retained its positive associations, and these were then supplemented by new linkages to Christianity, modernity, and Tok Pisin (see Figure 4.1).

Without realizing it, Gapun villagers began changing their linguistic practices as a result of the new associations that their long-standing cultural values of *hed* and *save* had begun to acquire. In a close study of children's language acquisition and socialization practices in the village, Kulick found that adults assumed that infants only a few months old spoke a few "words" in Taiap – short phrases that translate as "I'm getting out of here," "I'm sick of this," and "Stop it" – but after these initial utterances, children were not thought to be able to speak at all until about 18 months of age (Kulick 1992:202). Villagers considered these initial vocalizations to

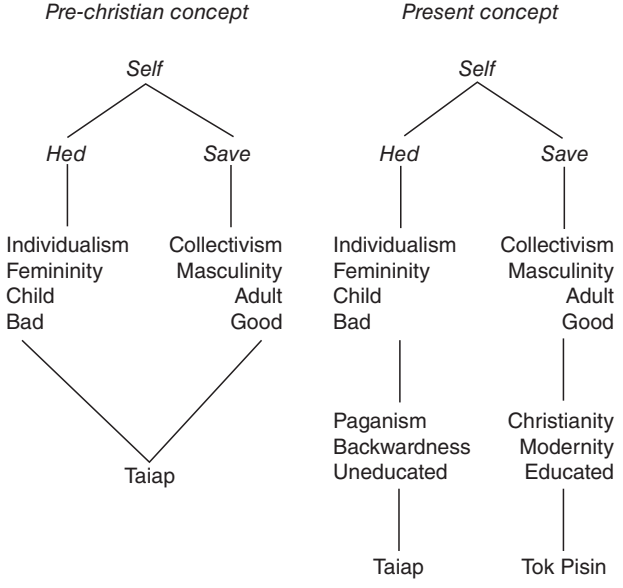


Figure 4.1 The cultural concepts of *hed* and *save* in Gapun, Papua New Guinea. *Source*: Kulick (1992:20). Reprinted with the permission of Cambridge University Press.

be indicative of young children's bad temper and selfishness – in other words, their *hed*.

Much as we saw above for the Kaluli that Schieffelin studied, the residents of Gapun spoke directly to their young children very rarely. When they did, they often mixed Taiap and Tok Pisin, just as they did in adult–adult talk. Kulick found one major difference, however: Gapun parents assumed that their children would find Tok Pisin both easier and preferable to speak as their *save* developed, so whenever parents really wanted their children to pay attention, they would switch into Tok Pisin. And other than the first few "words" that their children spoke in Taiap, parents assumed that all the rest of their attempts at speech were in Tok Pisin. Therefore, they reinforced these attempts to speak the language associated in the village with modernity, education, and other high-status qualities. The net result was that parents attributed the younger generation's shift in the village away from Taiap toward Tok Pisin to be caused not by the parents' own actions but by their children's preferences. The villagers' continued emphasis on the positive values of *save* and the negative values of *hed* under new social conditions ended up transforming linguistic practices in the village and led to the almost complete disappearance of Taiap.

Language Socialization throughout the Lifespan

One of the most valuable insights of the field of research known as language socialization is that the acquisition of new linguistic practices does not end with childhood. Every time a child, adolescent, or adult enters a new school, region of the country, religious community, profession, or other social group, the general process of becoming socialized into that community is accomplished largely through linguistic interactions and is often accompanied by the learning of new words or usages. Conversely, as people gradually become competent members of a new community, their relationship to both written and spoken language often changes. The process does not always involve successful adaptation, however, as Stanton Wortham (2005) has shown in the case of a ninth grader who starts the school year being seen as a student who can use academic discourse skillfully but

comes to be seen as one who disrupts class and fails to participate in suitable ways by the end of the year. Such "trajectories of socialization" can reveal the complex processes involved in learning to speak and behave appropriately in new settings and demonstrate the need to look at multiple linguistic and social interactions across various timescales (Wortham 2005:110).

In her research on the socialization of Hasidic Jewish girls and women, Ayala Fader (2007, 2009) demonstrates the thoroughly interwoven nature of linguistic, cultural, and religious practices in the Brooklyn neighborhood of Boro Park. In this community, during the time of Fader's research in the 1990s, men and women had complementary roles and responsibilities for reproducing Hasidic life. While men were supposed to focus on prayer and the study of Jewish texts, women were supposed to protect men from the "polluting effects" of Gentile society (Fader 2007:2). Women therefore often had more interactions with Gentiles and non-Hasidic Jews and, as a result, they came to speak better English than the men. Over the course of a marriage, however, once several children had been born, the men would often go out to work while their wives stayed home – a shift that resulted in changing linguistic competencies over a lifetime. Even though boys and girls were equally bilingual in Hasidic varieties of English and Yiddish in their early years, therefore – and even though their parents would have preferred them to stay that way – much as the Gapun parents were unable to dictate the outcome of their children's levels of fluency, so, too, were the Hasidic parents unsuccessful at ensuring that all their children remained equally bilingual. For the many social, educational, and religious reasons that Fader details, by the first grade, Hasidic girls and boys started to have different levels of proficiency in English and Yiddish, with girls speaking Hasidic English and boys speaking Hasidic Yiddish (Fader 2009:21).

Paying close attention to embodied forms of identity-making, such as hairstyles, clothing, and deportment, and integrating the language socialization approach with the theories of Foucault regarding morality, ethics, and the "techniques of the self," Fader shows how Hasidic girls learn to become modest Hasidic women. Explicit verbal and nonverbal instructions on the part of parents or teachers in the form of praising or shaming play a part in this socialization, but children and adolescents themselves are active agents in the pro-

cess as well. Just before they get married, young women are explicitly taught new linguistic and bodily practices in "bride class," but even before then, they learn about and usually internalize community norms regarding appropriately modest dress and behavior for Hasidic women. "Everyday talk about matchmaking, engagement, and marriage is an important way that girls on the brink of adulthood (ages eighteen to twenty-one) learn to become modest Hasidic wives, ultimately responsible for bringing up the next generation of believers" (Fader 2009:179).

In a very different context, Elizabeth Mertz (2007a) argues that law schools teach students to "think like lawyers" largely by socializing them into new ways of relating to written texts and new ways of using argumentative speech. Mertz tape-recorded the first-year Contracts course at eight different law schools around the United States to identify the similarities and differences across these institutions in their approaches to legal education. Despite the many differences, Mertz found that the eight schools shared a distinctive approach to teaching students how to decipher the conflicts at the heart of legal texts. In all eight schools, students learned to put aside all "irrelevant" details in the case, such as the social or historical setting, emotional issues, and even morality or justice, and focus instead on what gives the texts legal authority – that is, the previous cases and other legal texts that a court can cite as authorities in deciding the case at hand, and the procedural lineage of the case through various lower courts (Mertz 2007a:94). Thus, law school students learn to relate in a very different way to written texts.

This new relationship to written texts is accomplished largely through classroom interactions that, to a greater or lesser extent, follow the Socratic method, often considered "the signal approach to law school pedagogy" in which professors impart information not through lectures or explanations but through "an ongoing stream of questions designed to challenge unquestioned assumptions and reveal underlying legal principles" (Mertz 2007a:26). Through this form of argumentative exchange, professors model for students the assumption underlying the legal system in the United States: that legal truth emerges through argumentative dialogue (Mertz 2007a:108). Just as in many societies young children are socialized through linguistic routines that engage them in formulaic responses with or without

explicit instruction, so, too does the discourse in law school classrooms involve formulaic exchanges involving authoritative socializing such as the following (Mertz 2007a:125):[3]

Prof.: Let's put it slightly differently. Is the party making the promise, "if I buy the land, I'll sell it to you," surrendering any legal right?
Student: No.
Prof.: What do you mean, "no"? Try "yes."
Class: [[laughter]] (.02)
Prof.: Say (.) "yes."
Student: Yes.
Prof.: Why?
Class: [[laughter]]

In addition to these sorts of authoritative exchanges, interactions between professors and students in law schools also often involve reported speech (as can be seen in the example just given) and shifts in positions and roles. In Goffman's (1981) terms, students are frequently required to be the animators (the voice boxes) of stances or opinions for which they are not the authors (the composers) or the principals (the ones whose opinions are expressed). This sort of variable position-taking within argumentative classroom debates, Mertz claims, privileges language structure over content, and inculcates in students an ability to shift discursive positions rather than maintain fixed moral or emotional anchors. "Competence in this dialogic discourse form becomes a measure of one's ability to be and think like a lawyer" (Mertz 2007a:127).

The end result of immersion in law school linguistic interactions, Mertz maintains, is a profound transformation in students' senses of justice, morality, and themselves:

> If students entering the medical profession must endure a breaking down of everyday beliefs about the body, physicality, and death, students entering the legal profession undergo a linguistic rupture, a change in how they view and use language. This transition is, of course, itself signaled and performed through language, the language of the law school classroom. As in other forms of language socialization, new conceptions of morality and personhood are subtly intertwined with this shift to new uses of language. (2007a:22)

Thus, through the lens of language socialization, the transformation of a student into a professional such as a lawyer can be illuminated in interesting and helpful ways.

Another example of the usefulness of a language socialization approach for understanding complex sociocultural transitions that occur in adulthood is Lanita Jacobs-Huey's (2006) research on the professionalization processes that African American hair stylists undergo. By attending many workshops and seminars, conducting participant observation at hair salons, and capturing many of the interactions in these settings on tape, Jacobs-Huey was able to identify several important ways in which cosmetologists were encouraged to demonstrate their expertise through language.

For example, in many of the seminars for African American hair care specialists that Jacobs-Huey attended, leaders urged participants to consider themselves "hair doctors" and to use specialized discourse that sounded scientific. In order to set themselves apart from their customers, many of whom had a great deal of experience styling their own or others' hair, the stylists were told to employ professional-sounding terms such as "silken" instead of "press" (Jacobs-Huey 2006:40). These seminars thus instructed stylists not only in specific hair care techniques but also in how to think of themselves as professionals and how to convey their professional expertise to their customers through their language use. Participants therefore became socialized into a particular professional identity as they learned specialized terminology. The same process can be seen in many other educational and professional arenas; doctors, lawyers, police officers, teachers, and college students (among many others) all learn how to enact their professional or social roles at the same time that they are learning specialized linguistic practices associated with those roles.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we learned about the diversity across cultures in the ways that parents interact with their young children as they are learning to speak. Studies by researchers such as Kulick (1992), Ochs (1988), and Schieffelin (1990) demonstrate that baby talk is not at all universal. What *is* universal is the ability of all children to become fluent in their native language(s). The cultural values, language ideologies, and social

practices of a particular community cannot (barring severe abuse, of course) prevent children from learning to speak, but those values, ideologies, and practices can indeed influence important aspects of the language acquisition process, such as the order in which certain grammatical structures are learned, or even whether a particular language is acquired at all (as we saw with Taiap). Language ideologies can also cause some people to view low-income homes as linguistically impoverished and suggest overly simplistic programs to address this alleged "Language Gap."

We also learned in this chapter that the language socialization process does not end with childhood. Even adults who never learn a second language nevertheless continue to learn new ways of using language in different social contexts as they go through life. Taking on new social roles, as happens after joining a sorority or fraternity, becoming a parent, or acquiring a new profession, will almost always be accompanied by – and at least partially accomplished through – the learning of new ways of speaking.

In sum, the field of language acquisition and socialization research sheds helpful light on how children learn their first languages as well as on how adults navigate their way among various social groups throughout their lives.